

become millionaires. But I had also heard about quite a few Indian blue chip firms that had become history after being overrun by competitors.

And lastly, I had heard too many horror stories about fake shares. The perils of delivery-based investment – in which the buyer takes delivery of the physical shares – were once again manifest in the wake of the securities scam.

The special court appointed to try the scam-related cases had ‘notified’ entities suspected of involvement in the scam and against whom criminal charges had been filed. These entities included Harshad Mehta, his associate firms and some others. Any share certificate that bore the name of any of the notified entities was seized by the custodian entrusted with recovering the dues owed to the banks and the taxes owed to the government. It did not matter that in many cases the shares had been bought before the entities had been notified. In other cases, the shares had changed hands a few times after the notified entities had sold them. Often, investors who were the buyers of shares sold by the notified entities did not send the shares for transfer to their own names. They would hold on to the shares for a while before selling them, and the shares would change hands several times until the investor at the end of the chain sent them for transfer to his name. This further hardened my resolve against buying shares for delivery.

Barring one or two, all our firm’s clients lost heavily when the market tanked. They had all invested heavily in Harshad’s favourite stocks. A few of them defaulted on huge payments, and the losses had to be borne by the firm. My owner himself had taken some big positions on which he took hefty hits. Our firm was now poised on the brink of a shutdown.

By July, my employer decided to get out of the broking business and try his hand at something else. He owed me around Rs 50,000, including my commissions. He added another Rs 50,000 to it. ‘Lala, I would have liked to be even more generous, but I am really stretched at this point,’ he said apologetically.

I believed him. He never haggled while sharing profits from the deals I made, and never questioned me on the deals that went wrong. I really respected the man. And, while he may not have been able to give me a handsome severance package, he recommended me to one of the masters of the trade, Govindbhai, who happened to be a good friend of his.

I had heard about Govindbhai though I did not know him personally. He was what they called the broker’s broker. His speciality was execution of